

BEING VALUES VERSUS APPEARANCE VALUES -- SELF-IDENTIFICATION

Greetings and divine blessings for all of you, my most beloved friends. May this last lecture of this working year resume in next year's series and at the same time summarize your inner path on a very deep level. The growth and the change that has taken place and continues to take place with so many of you is heartwarming and a most joyous sight to behold. You have grown much, much more, my beloved friends, than you can realize, for you are in the middle of it. More of you change over onto a new level of operation in which the old attitude of taking, wanting, demanding, and not giving is transformed into an attitude of love, giving, devotion, and sincerity. And that is truly the key, the key to happiness and abundance. There is no other key. But to talk about it on a superficial level before one is even aware of the non-giving attitude is pointless. You have to travel through all the levels of your lower self to recognize them before this key can become meaningful. In this lecture I want to show you on a yet deeper level how this relates to the problem of {value and self-identification}.

There are fundamentally two value systems by which a human being is governed, with which he operates. The one is the {being values} and the other is the {appearance values}. Now, we have talked about this in a more superficial and cursory way. However, I will attempt to show you in this lecture the ramifications of these two value systems. Most human beings function on the level of the appearance values. I would say it is only the most evolved who have already gone through an extensive path of self-purification and transformation, who function according to real values, {for the sake of what is, not for the sake of appearance in the eyes of others}. Here, too, of course, as in so many other areas, it is not either/or. There are degrees. A person can function in some areas of his life with the true values and in other areas still be bound to the importance of appearance. And only gradually in the course of this pathwork will the former take over more and more where the latter had prevailed before.

To begin with, before such an extensive path is undertaken and for some time after it has begun, humanity functions in most areas with the appearance values. Now let us see the difference.

The appearance values always aim at the impression you give in the eyes of others. It may have its crasser manifestations such as aiming for approval and selling out your truth in order to impress others or be thought of in the highest terms by them. This can be quite obvious and overt, but it can also be quite subtle and covert and not so easy to detect. The inner focus is subtly geared in many activities, desires, and directions, in a secret, hidden, semi-conscious expectation and concern about "what will I be thought of." The fear of negative reaction from others causes a tremendous amount of anxiety. So the appearance value system is insidious and poisonous. It is much more harmful, my friends, than it may appear. For it truly disconnects you from your inner reality, from your higher self, from the truth of the situation, and from the sincerity of your

involvement and investment. I hardly need to emphasize how many further, most harmful results this causes.

If you start observing yourself from this point of view, you will discover the many areas that first appear ever so subtle in your field of vision. Yet when you become more conscious of them, when you tune in on them, you find they are not so subtle and that actually the value system of appearance, as opposed to the value system of {being}, makes all the difference in the world. The appearance values, no matter how strong and apparently loving or creative the effort and goal may be, always connote an insincerity. For what you do is done for effect -- either directly through the activity or in order to attain power and money for the sole sake of proving your values. When you operate with {being} values it means that you do what you do for the sake of what is, for the sake of the truth of the particular area in question, for the sake of {being}. This may simply mean to do the best you have to offer regardless of others' opinions but so that the activity fulfills its innate purpose. Or it may mean to make an offering to God out of the act or the endeavor, to contribute love, beauty, goodwill, comfort, something constructive to the world, to another person -- again, regardless of others' opinions or even their noticing the effort and the effect. Whether you make an important humanitarian contribution, a work of art, a scientific project, or the smallest, most insignificant daily chore makes no difference. In the latter instance, it is just as important to do every daily activity in the spirit of being, not appearance.

When you act, work, and accomplish -- again, in large and small issues -- for the sheer sake of what the act itself represents rather than "using" it in order to substitute your sense of self-value, this always finally amounts to an act of love, to spiritual sincerity, to a giving and enriching act. And what you give to others, you give to yourself. Not giving to others deprives you even more than it deprives others and makes you incapable of receiving what is available for you.

When you operate on the being level, some very drastic changes occur. These are by-products that you might never have connected with the origin, namely the integrity of your motive on the deepest level. Let me give you an example. When you are attacked or judged or criticized or rejected, as long as you operate with the value system of appearance, you will feel devastated in your total being. And how can it be different? If you attach your self-worth and your self-esteem to what you appear in the eyes of others, you must feel annihilated when you appear in a bad light in the eyes of others, be it in ever so small an issue. You feel you lose your inner ground. You are no longer centered in yourself. Of course, you never really are centered as long as you are governed by appearance values, but you are deluded about this fact as long as criticism does not come to you. You {seem} centered when you receive praise and admiration because you feel gratified at the moment, but you are unaware of the anxiety that eats you up, even in those most propitious moments, as long as you receive your worth from others. For you must constantly worry about your ability to maintain this de-centered state of receiving self-value from others. You have no real control over your sense of self-value.

Operating with being values, on the other hand, brings a deep inner security. This is not to say that hostile judgments, unfairness, and the intent to put you down would not hurt you. But, {there is a world of difference between this kind of hurt that can never shake your foundation and the hurt that does shake your foundation}. If you operate with appearance values, your foundation is shaken and even seems to crumble when your appearance is negative. This does not happen when you operate in the deep security of being. Given your total integrity and knowledge of your

real motives on the most hidden levels, the truth of your giving, the sincerity of your investment, the pursuit of your goal for its own sake without hind thoughts and ulterior motives; your security in your own value will be so grounded in reality that no matter how you are being judged and how it may hurt you, you experience the unshakable truth of your core. Then your value of yourself is not dependent on the opinion of others, on their knowing your assets and ignoring your liabilities. This creates a centeredness and a security and an awareness of your eternal values that cannot be esteemed in words.

Another ramification in regard to this topic is the problem of {identity}. When you operate with appearance values, you have no identity. You stake your claim to your own identity on the opinion of other people, on how you appear in their eyes. So when you are praised and honored, you derive a great momentary sense of gratification and confirmation of yourself and perhaps even a temporary exhilaration, but it is built on shaky ground. When that admiration and approval are withheld or perhaps even reversed, the ground is shaking and you become lost. You cease to feel your own identity. The false sense of your identity has been crushed, and the real has not yet been established.

As long as appearance values hold sway, underneath the surface you constantly eat away at your self-esteem because deep inside you know you are not in truth when you put so much on the level of appearance. You cannot connect with the identity of your higher self. Since you know that you only appear to give, doing it for ulterior motives, for something you want to gain in a prideful, vain way; on a very deep level, you doubt yourself. So when others doubt you, distrust you, criticize you in any way; on the surface you may be very indignant, and you may be very defensive, and you may be argumentative about this and that issue. But inwardly you cannot find your center since you doubt your integrity about the way you operate generally. Perhaps you don't lack integrity in the specific issue, but you have no sense of your true identity and your true value since you forsake the true value system -- and therefore your knowing of your real identity -- by adopting the appearance values.

Another aspect of these two possibilities of value systems that forms a permeating overall attitude toward yourself and toward life is your ability to perceive truth in others. And this is a very profound and important aspect of this whole topic. Try to go beyond the mere words which you have heard me mention in one form or another before. When you function in your giving, in your activities in a deeply committed sincere spirit, then whatever you do occurs in wholehearted investment of your best faculties. But when this spirit is not there and the appearance values reign, you can never really know whether you are right or wrong; whether others are right or wrong; to what extent you are right or wrong, or are the others right or wrong; in what particular area are you right and in what area the others are right; in what particular area are you wrong and in what way the others are wrong. All these questions plague you although you may succeed to deny yourself awareness of them as you unfortunately succeed to deny yourself awareness of the fact that the appearance values undermine your integrity. These denials are the very cause of confusion and create a fog over such issues and questions when you would need clarity in order to know who you are. So you flounder, you grope, but you do not grope in a healthy way. You are truly confused. You are upset, and the struggle is painful because it is a struggle that covers up the inner lack of security that can only come from the deep sincerity of commitment and giving. This lack of giving and commitment eats away at your psychic guts, if I may say so. It makes you doubtful of everything you do, of everything you think.

You may adopt an artificial brittle security that is not built on sound and deep self-esteem. The groping that is healthy, that is necessary, that is the doorway to security takes on a very different form. It feels different. It need not be covered up. It is a beautiful, growth-producing struggle. I can only deal with the subtleties here and hint at the difference in self-experience. For the words cannot convey the enormous difference between the hurt of being misjudged when you do not lose your being from it and from the hurt that destroys you. Nor can words convey the difference between the struggle of real growth and search and the false struggle of covering up your hidden lack of identity and lack of security about your values.

When you decide again and again and again, every day and every hour, in all of your activities to give your very best in truth whether or not you get admiration, whether or not it is being recognized, but for the sheer sincerity, truthfulness, beauty, and love of God, love of yourself, love of life; then little by little, almost as if it were a by-product, a deep inner, secure, and intuitive knowledge arises about issues and matters where you were uncertain before, where you needed to defend your uncertainty, where you were truly groping in the dark in an eternal either/or, in an eternal duality. Even if your intellect already embraces the unitive system and knows theoretically it is not one versus the other, it is only a theory. This is so different from the experience of clarity that you get from being connected and identified with your innermost center -- that {intuitive certainty of what is what}, a certainty about yourself, about others, about life. It is a relaxed inner knowing and a deep peace and clarity that no one can take away from you. It is free from all defense, and it comes only as a result of true self-esteem that is built on that very sincerity of giving and commitment, on the being values we are talking about. {What an illusion it is to hope for self-esteem and security on any other basis but the inner truth of real giving for its own sake}!

Yet another aspect of these two value systems is {knowing what you really want}. If you do not know your higher self, if you are disconnected from it and cannot identify with it, if all your energy is funneled into the appearance values and therefore you lack centeredness, how can you possibly know what you want? Everything is colored and determined by the appearance values. If appearance in the eyes of others takes precedence over what {you} may want, you could not even allow yourself to know what you want. For if what {you} want might reduce honor and esteem from others, it may seem preferable for you to talk yourself into wanting what you ought to want, i.e., what you think would earn you praise and admiration. So you have a great inner investment when you operate with appearance values, to not experience what you desire, what may be your destiny, what is your real potentiality, your real fulfillment, your true longing. It may not conform with the appearance values you have borrowed to use as your system. And, of course, many systems of appearance values exist, while only one being value exists as far as your own higher self is concerned. Individual as it is, with all the infinite varieties of self-expression of all higher selves, your being value can never interfere with the higher self value system of another person. There can never be conflict between one person's being values and another person's being values. When conflict arises, at least one of them is hooked on the appearance level, possibly without knowing it. Only deep self-confrontation can yield the answer. But the expressions vary constantly and in many ways, in many wondrous ways!

By contrast, appearance values interfere with one another and are at the same time stiff, rigid, unvaried in their conformity and dullness. Individualistic as they may {appear}, they lack the flexibility and the breathing life that only being values can have.

If you do not dare to know what you really desire and long for, you suffer unfulfillment, for the false goals of appearance values can never fulfill you. You constantly hunt for something that never lives up to your expectations. Perhaps even more insidious and painful is the very fact that you do not know what you really want. For a while you may succeed in hiding this fact from yourself by ardently attempting to produce imaginary desires and goals and acting as if you believed in them. But sooner or later you find out that you are also confused about your own desires, longings, and goals. And obviously this only adds to your lack of self-identity, of not knowing who you are, and the despair about it.

Appearance values eternally, as long as you adopt them, disconnect you from your true desire, from knowing what is you, essentially you -- in expression, in direction, in self-expressions, in talents, in taste, in opinions, in philosophy, in true feelings, in your way of life, in your potentialities to develop, in general trends of life as well as in little everyday decisions. The decisions of what to do and what not to do in the most mundane matters as well as in the overall direction of one's life are always determined by whether you operate with being values or appearance values.

So you never truly know what is really you and what you really want when you are governed and polluted by appearance values. You borrow an imagined desire that fits into the appearance value system you have adopted. And when you follow that through, of course, it leaves you empty. No wonder it is a disappointment even if you do succeed in it at a tremendous expenditure of your energy system. The tremendous effort is only necessary because your energy system functions contrary to your true higher self, to your reality, to who you really are. So despair and a sense of futility and hopelessness about life arise. You say to yourself, "I have done all this. I have invested so much. I have tried so hard. I used so much effort to accomplish this and that and the other thing. I feel dissatisfied, I feel empty, I do not even know who I really am. What is the use?" This happens whether or not one "succeeds" in the false goals of the appearance value system. Most human beings are quite conscious of such occasional thoughts and feelings, but they do not know why they have them.

On the other hand, the functioning of being values creates a very different situation. Since you are not afraid of finding your desire, your direction, your expression whether or not others approve and applaud your choices, you can afford the luxury to inwardly relax and let out your true being with its expressions and its desires. And you will therefore find what it is you really want. What a tremendous richness to know what you really want! How rare a phenomenon in this world of yours! How hard the struggle of self-purification must be in order to come to this blessed event of finding the treasure of knowing what you really want. It is not something to come by so easily. You have to eliminate, and before you eliminate, you have to detect where you eat away at your true being and true expression by borrowing what you think you {ought to want} in order to be what you {ought to be} and not what you really {want} and really {are}.

When you function with appearance values, you cannot trust your perceptions and your desires. And indeed they are not trustworthy. Many, many times your perceptions and your desires are tainted by the falsehood of the appearance value system in which you live and with which you have disoriented yourself. So you continuously doubt your perceptions and your desires. Something may be desirable, and you do not even know, "Is it right, is it good, is it me? Am I

perhaps wrong in wanting it? Is it beyond my capacities?" You flounder, you do not know, the cohesion is gone.

On the other hand, when you have a deep, sincere, genuine, commitment to invest your best in all your activities, in all you do; when your integrity makes sure that you do not have other hidden motives but give for the sake of giving (which is always giving for God's sake), then you will experience sooner or later the incredible {miracle that your heart's desire is God's will}. At first, by old habitual standards, of course, you will distrust that your desire is good and right. Even when you already operate with being values, you are used to distrusting your desires. They have been polluted for such a long, long time -- centuries and centuries -- that even when there is no longer any need to distrust them, you doubt them. You automatically assume that your desire must be wrong. You automatically assume, somewhere in a hidden corner of your inner personality, that if somebody disagrees with you, he might be right and you are not trustworthy. But as you begin to discover the effects of the being values, you discover the miracle that what you thought was the work of the greedy little child who has these pleasurable and forbidden desires may indeed and will indeed turn out to be {the will of God}, while when you function with appearance values, the will of God actually is, or at least must seem to be, eternally contrary to your desires. It often is, because your real self cannot enjoy to do things you do not really want. The superimposed, false desires neither give real pleasure nor are they the will of God. They are dictated by appearance values. Such desires and God's will are opposites. Sometimes the desires seem pleasurable, perhaps because they seem naughty and rebellious and are thus contrary to God's will. At other times they may not even be contrary to God's will, but you will never know when you are disconnected from your truth. And you must be disconnected from your truth when you function with appearance values and do not do things in a true spirit of giving, whether others notice it or not.

I want to mention one last aspect in regard to this topic, which will be the foreshadowing of much of the work we shall do in the next working year. And that is the creating, the re-creating, and the molding of life and soul substance. It deals with {the power of the word}. It says in the Bible, "In the beginning was the Word." There is a very deep meaning to this. The word is the first creative impulse. The word is the expression of an intent, and the word gives form to the intent. From the word can then follow action, creative action, the follow-through process. The word is the first blueprint. It is the plan. There is a tremendous power in the word whether the word is actually spoken with loud voice or spoken in silence with an inner voice, affirmative and decisive. The word is the chisel. It is the tool with which you mold and give form to the soul substance that dwells in you and in which you simultaneously dwell. It surrounds you just as much as it penetrates you.

So every thought and intent is a powerful agent. From the one-pointedness, from the conflict-free attitude behind the uttered word comes the creative power. Now you can perhaps see quite easily that when you function with appearance values and are consequently disconnected from the truth of your real being, from the real values, the truth of any issue of the moment, from the truth of your real desires -- legitimate desires -- you are disconnected from knowing your Godself. In this case many conflicting levels must also exist. Your word -- uttered with voice or uttered in thought -- cannot have the strength, power, and clarity it needs to have in order to create. There are so many conflicting thoughts, desires, feelings, and intentionalities that a perpetual flickering of interfering, self-defeating short-circuit actions occur, one canceling out the other. There is a lot of agitation coming from those conflicting levels, from the uncertainty and confusion that also create a sort of lightning effect on the level of energies, but in a destructive, self-defeating way. Thus the

word has no true power. The true power lies in the unconflictedness, the oneness, and the wholeness of the utterance. Feelings, desires, concepts, perceptions, knowing must all be one cohesive, compatible, fused energy stream. Then the power of the word is enormous. And no matter what you create, with the word as the first agent of creation, it must take form and shape.

When you discover difficulty in what you create, look at the disorder of your various levels of thinking and feeling, at the contradictions, and look how this emanates from the appearance level by which you function. As you see this, you will make yet another step toward committing yourself to being values -- not just generally and philosophically, but specifically in every act of your daily life that you undertake, as well as in the general direction of your life. And if you do not yet know what the general direction is, you can use the being value system as you grope, ask, and wait receptively for the answer. Then that is also following the being values. That is the struggle that is producing life and light, and not chaos and confusion.

We will also deal in the future with other aspects of the power of the word -- the word you speak, the word you think, and the influence you have with every word whether thinking it or speaking. For you underestimate your own power when you feel distrustful of yourself because you operate with appearance values. You think then so little of yourself that you cannot possibly consider how powerful your emanations, your expressions, and your attitudes are. They can hurt, they can influence, they can harm; or they can heal, they can help, and they can produce life.

If you think of yourself as nothing, even while you are still in the error and lack of integrity of appearance values, you still insult your inherent divine manifestation. This is yet another proof that you are one with everything that is. If you insult yourself because you underestimate yourself and your power, you must hurt, harm, and insult others. It is very false to imagine that he who thinks so little of himself is humble and good. This is one of the many dualistic misconceptions your world is permeated with. Self-devaluation is equated with humility and goodness, and self-value is equated with pride and arrogance. Nothing could be further from the truth. For if you know your own value and your own power, and you respect this value, no matter what you do now and no matter where you are now, then indeed you must be considerate of others and value them. So there is no possibility that you devalue yourself and value others or vice versa. This is yet another proof, as I said, of the illusion that you and others are separate. All is one, all is one. These are words, but perhaps if you look deeply into this in terms of what I spoke of in this lecture, you will truly understand the meaning.

Be blessed, all of you, my very dearest ones. Go further into the light center of the race of man, of your innermost being that is the innermost being of all that is, that ever was, and that ever will be. Joyfully, you are blessed.

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